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ACCORDING TO BORIS BECKER, SINNER AND ALCARAZ CAN BE DEFINED AS THE DJOKOVIC AND FEDERER OF THE FUTURE, BUT ONLY AFTER CONSIDERING 'PROPER PROPORTIONS'

Tennis' current sensations, Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner, have already **emulated** the initial era of the Fedal rivalry by winning Grand Slams and becoming good friends.

Paul Fein

During Jannik Sinner's 7-6(4), 6-3 victory over 24-time major champion Novak Djokovic in the Shanghai Masters final, Carlos Alcaraz, seated next to Roger Federer, was seen listening intently to the latter's conversation with Juan Carlos Ferrero.

What could Alcaraz, coached by the astute Ferrero, have learned about technique, tactics, and other relevant topics from 20-time Major winner Federer, one of the smartest players in tennis history?

And how can Alcaraz use that knowledge against Sinner, Djokovic, and the best of the rest, including rookie sensation Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard, a 6'8" monster server?

This observer would love to know how Federer coped with and rebounded quickly from heartbreaking defeats, such as his record 24 losses after holding one or more match points. How the Swiss maestro controlled his penchant for crowd-pleasing but high-risk trick shots, particularly on critical points, and why he rarely suffered

major injuries or lost his passion for practice and competition.

Just 11 days earlier, Alcaraz had defeated Sinner for the third straight time — a 6-7 (6), 6-4, 7-6 (3) thriller in the China Open final in Beijing. Meanwhile, the Shanghai Open final victory was Sinner's third consecutive against Djokovic.

Asked about the similarities between his game and Sinner's, The Djoker offered this serious, accurate appraisal. "All around, he has every shot in the game. He's improved his serve tremendously. I think that became a big weapon.

He's just very aggressive from the baseline; as soon as he's got a shorter ball, he's taking the initiative. Just very solid from forehand and backhand, doesn't make too many mistakes, and just tries to take away the time from the opponent.

"That's something that reminds me of myself throughout my career, that's what I've done for so many years consistently," said Djokovic. "Playing fast-paced tennis, taking away time from the opponent, suffocating the opponent, in a certain way. You want your opponent to always feel under pressure from your shots, from your speed, from your presence on the court. So, he's got that. This year he's been so consistent. It's really, really impressive."

The stats confirm Sinner's improved serving. On hard courts, where he captured his first two Grand Slam titles this season, he has held serve a superb 91 per cent of the time compared to 82 per cent in 2022 and 88 per cent in 2023. The hard-court parallel between Sinner,